

PeerPath

Business Plan & Execution Strategy

"The place where no student has to figure it out alone."

Daniyal Rashid

Co-Founder & CEO

Rotman Commerce
University of Toronto

FOUNDED BY

Nathan Ho

Co-Founder & CTO

Rotman Commerce
University of Toronto

Jackson Del Ciano

Co-Founder & COO

Rotman Commerce
University of Toronto

June 2026 · Confidential

PEERPATH

1. Executive Summary

We built PeerPath because we've both experienced what it feels like to show up to university not knowing anyone, unsure what to do, and too embarrassed to admit either. First year is lonely in a way nobody talks about. You're surrounded by thousands of people and somehow completely alone.

The platforms that exist don't help. LinkedIn makes you pretend you have it together. Reddit is a mess. Discord falls apart. Group chats you weren't invited to. So students just figure it out alone. Or they don't figure it out at all.

The one thing PeerPath has to do: let a first-year post a question and get a real, helpful answer from someone who's been there, within 24 hours. Everything else is secondary.

1.2M+ Canadian post-secondary students (target market)	87% Students report feeling lonely in first year*	\$0 Raised (bootstrapped) Phase 1 target	200 Active Rotman users target by Month 4
--	--	---	--

* Illustrative figure based on widely reported student wellness data.

2. The Problem

The problem isn't that students lack access to information. It's that they can't find the right person at the right moment. And they're too scared to ask anyway.

Every first-year at Rotman has the same questions: Which profs are actually good? How does recruiting really work? Is it normal to feel this lost? The answers exist. in the heads of second and third-years who went through it 12 months ago. But there's no easy way to reach them. No platform designed for exactly this.

Platform	What it does	Why it fails students
----------	--------------	-----------------------

LinkedIn	Professional networking	Too performative: no one admits they're lost
Reddit	Anonymous Q&A;	No accountability; goes toxic fast
Discord	Real-time chat	Chaotic, fragmented, already cliquey
Facebook Groups	Announcements	Dead. Nobody under 22 is checking it
School Clubs	In-person community	Exclusive; hard to find if you're new
Group Chats	Peer coordination	You can only join if someone invites you

The gap isn't features. It's trust. Students don't feel safe being honest on anonymous platforms, and they feel too exposed on professional ones. No existing platform is both verified and warm. That's the gap PeerPath fills.

3. Product Vision

"PeerPath is the place where no student has to figure it out alone."

We chose that mission carefully. 'Figuring it out' covers everything: academics, friends, recruiting, mental health, what to do with your degree. It applies to every year, not just first. And it doesn't imply hierarchy. A fourth-year is still figuring things out. So is a grad student. So, honestly, are alumni two years into their careers.

The word we deliberately avoided is 'networking.' The moment a platform feels like networking, people start performing. They stop being honest. The community dies.

What PeerPath is NOT

- A networking app. Connections happen naturally when people help each other. That's the byproduct, not the goal.
- A mentorship marketplace. One-way mentorship burns out the mentors. PeerPath is a community, not a help desk.
- A social media feed. We're not optimising for time-on-app. We're optimising for the moment someone feels less alone.
- Another Discord server. Real-time chat is fine for coordination. It's terrible for building the kind of trust we're after.

The Feeling We're Building Towards

When someone opens PeerPath, they should feel: **"These are my people."** Not 'these are strangers I should network with.' That difference sounds small. It's everything.

4. Unique Value Proposition

Our edge is verified context. When you post something on PeerPath, you're not shouting into a void. You're talking to people in your program, your year, maybe your exact courses. That context changes everything. Asking 'is RSM432 as hard as people say?' feels totally different when you know the people reading it actually took RSM432.

Three things no other platform combines

01	Verified Identity University email login. Every user is a real student. No anonymity, no fake accounts, no performance.
02	Contextual Relevance Your feed is filtered by year, program, and courses. You see what matters to you, not everything.
03	Warmth by Design Community guidelines, moderation standards, and product defaults all push toward generosity, not virality.

Why not just use Reddit?

Reddit is the closest thing that exists to what PeerPath is trying to do. students do use it (r/UofT, r/RotmanCommerce) and some of it is genuinely useful. But Reddit has a structural problem: it was built for the internet, not for your campus. That difference matters more than it sounds.

	Reddit	PeerPath
Who's answering?	Anyone on the internet. Could be a student, could be a troll, could be a bot.	A verified student at your school. You can see their year and program.

Accountability	Pseudonymous. Bad advice has no consequences. Dismissive replies are common.	Real name, real identity. People are more careful when they can be traced.
Context	None. A post about RSM432 is read by people who've never heard of it.	Your posts reach people in your program, your year, your exact courses.
Tone	Upvotes reward what's entertaining or controversial, not what's most helpful.	Designed for generosity. Moderated by people who care about the community.
Knowledge lifespan	Threads go stale, get buried, or disappear. Finding old posts is painful.	Good answers are archived by course and searchable by future students.
Belonging	You're anonymous in a crowd of millions. Easy to feel invisible.	You're a named member of a small community. People remember you.

Our moat

It's not the code. Any well-funded team can copy features in six months. The moat is community culture: the norms, the trust, the feeling you get when you open the app. That takes years to build and is nearly impossible to replicate quickly. Which is why we have to get the culture right before we scale, not after.

5. Product Strategy & MVP

Why we're not building everything

Student app graveyards are full of products that tried to do too much too soon. We're doing the opposite. Before we write a single line about matching algorithms or mentor profiles, we need to prove one thing works: post a question, get a real answer, feel like someone actually cared. That's the MVP.

MVP goal: A first-year posts a question and gets a genuine response from someone who's been there, within 24 hours.

What we're building first

Feature	Why now	Why not later
Verified email sign-up	Without trust, nothing else works	N/A
Year + program + course profile	Context is what makes questions feel safe to ask	N/A
Course-tagged question feed	This is the core product. Where belonging actually happens.	N/A
Direct messaging (after first interaction)	Relationships need somewhere to go after the first reply	N/A
Weekly digest email	Keeps people coming back without needing them to form a habit	N/A

What we're not building yet

- Matching algorithms: organic discovery is fine when the community is small
- Mobile app: validate retention on web first before investing in native
- Formal mentor profiles: that framing turns the community into a help desk
- Gamification: points and badges make helping feel like a chore
- Multiple universities: go deep at one school before going wide

The feed isn't just for first-years

A third-year posting 'looking for someone to run mock cases before Deloitte first rounds' gets immediate value. A fourth-year sharing their Bay Street comp breakdown builds real reputation. The feed has to work for everyone. That's what makes it a community instead of a freshman help hotline.

6. Incentive Design & Community Mechanics

This is the hardest part. Every peer platform dies the same way: upper-year students stop showing up. The usual fix (badges, points, leaderboards) makes things worse. Nobody wants to feel like they're doing volunteer work.

The right question isn't 'how do we reward upper-years for helping?' It's **'why would a busy third-year open PeerPath on a Tuesday afternoon?'** If we can't answer that, the platform collapses.

Peer Discovery	3RD & 4TH YEARS	There's no good way to find a case comp partner, a co-founder, or a study group for RSM443. LinkedIn is too formal. Friend groups are already locked in. PeerPath with year + course filters is the only place this actually works.
Legible Reputation	ALL UPPER YEARS	Not a badge. A real track record: 'Helped 34 students with recruiting questions. Mentioned by name in 5 LinkedIn posts.' That's social capital, the kind that follows you after graduation and that recruiters actually notice.
Information Advantage	2ND, 3RD & 4TH YEARS	Active members see things first: job postings shared peer-to-peer before they go public, real comp data from people who just finished internships, recruiting timelines from people who just went through it. The community becomes a serious information edge.
An Audience for Good Work	4TH YEARS & ALUMNI	A fourth-year's comprehensive guide to Rotman recruiting is searchable, permanent, and attached to their name on PeerPath. That's meaningfully different from a Discord message that disappears in 48 hours.
Alumni Connection	ALUMNI	Alumni get a low-friction way to stay connected to a place they actually cared about, and to find talented people without going through formal channels. Their presence matters to current students too: it signals that PeerPath is worth investing in.

The flywheel

First-years join because there's finally somewhere safe to ask questions. Second-years stay because they're finding study partners and processing what they just went through. Third-years come for recruiting intel and peer connections, and stay because they're building a reputation that actually means something. Fourth-years give back because the cost is low and the community makes them feel valued. Alumni stick around because it's the best low-effort way to stay connected and find good people. Each group feeds the next.

7. Go-to-Market & Growth Strategy

Community products have a specific failure mode: you launch publicly before the culture is set, strangers flood in, the tone goes wrong, and the people who cared most leave first. We're not doing that.

The first 200 users set the culture that the next 20,000 inherit. That means we're slow and deliberate early on. By design.

Phase 1	No public launch. No social posts. We walk into the Rotman atrium and personally invite 50 first-years and 20 upper-years. We get a real endorsement from the Commerce Society; not just a share, but actual co-signing. We seed answers manually in the first few weeks if we have to. 'Active' means posted or replied in the last two weeks.
Phase 2	Engineering, Arts & Science, UTSC, one at a time. Each faculty has its own culture and that needs to feel native, not transplanted. One strong student ambassador per faculty before we open the doors. We don't go to all of U of T at once. That kills the coherence we're building.
Phase 3	Same playbook, replicable: one ambassador, 30 personal invites, organic growth from there. Scarcity helps. 'PeerPath just launched at McGill' is a better launch than 'PeerPath is available everywhere.' We go to schools with strong alumni cultures first.

The weekly digest email

Even students who don't develop a daily habit will open a well-curated email: '3 things students in your courses are asking this week.' Email is underrated for community products. It's our most important retention tool in Phase 1, and it costs almost nothing to run.

8. Financial Plan

Year 1: Bootstrap

Phase 1 is deliberately cheap. We don't need to spend money to figure out if people want this. We need to talk to people. The main costs are infrastructure and legal, both of which are minimal at this stage.

Category	Estimated Cost (CAD)	Notes
Hosting (Vercel + Supabase/Railway)	\$50–150/mo	Free tiers get us far early on
Domain + email	~\$5/mo annualised	
Design tools (Figma)	\$0–20/mo	Free tier is sufficient
Legal (incorporation)	\$500–1,500 one-time	NUANS + federal or provincial incorporation
Marketing	\$0	Grassroots only. Spending money here would be premature
Year 1 Total	~\$3,000–5,000	Manageable without any external funding

Year 2: Small team, if the numbers justify it

If Phase 1 produces 200+ retained users, we raise a small pre-seed round. targeting \$75k–\$100k from CDL, ICUBE, or angels who understand student communities. We use it to hire one part-time developer and one community lead.

Category	Estimated Cost (CAD/yr)	Notes
Part-time contract developer	\$20,000–40,000	1–2 developers, part-time
Infrastructure (at scale)	\$3,000–8,000	Grows with user base

Community management	\$10,000–15,000	Part-time community lead
Ambassador program	\$5,000	Students at each faculty/school
Legal + accounting	\$3,000	Annual compliance
Year 2 Total	~\$40,000–70,000	Pre-seed territory

Revenue: not before Year 2

We don't touch monetisation until we have real retention and a community that students would actually miss if it disappeared. Monetising early destroys the trust we're building. When we do monetise, it comes from parties who benefit from the community, not from the students themselves.

Revenue Stream	Description	When
Recruiter Access	Companies pay to post opportunities to a verified, engaged pool. Think Handshake, but students actually trust it.	Year 2 (5,000+ users)
University Partnerships	Schools pay for anonymised insights on what students are struggling with. They already spend on student success.	Year 2–3
Premium Features	Priority visibility for mentorship requests, alumni network access. Never lock core community features.	Year 3+

9. Risks & What Could Kill This

We're not going to sugarcoat this section. These are the real risks, in order of how worried we actually are about them.

CRITICAL	The Empty Room <i>Risk:</i> A first-year joins, asks something, and gets no response for three days. They never come back. They tell their friends it's dead. This is the fastest way PeerPath dies. <i>Fix:</i> We don't open the doors until we have enough active upper-years to guarantee fast responses. In early weeks, we answer questions ourselves if we have to. Internal rule: nothing goes unanswered for more than 24 hours.
HIGH	Moderation <i>Risk:</i> One dismissive reply to a first-year's 'dumb question.' One toxic thread that sits up for 12 hours. The warm culture we're building is fragile early on. One bad experience can spread fast. <i>Fix:</i> We write the community guidelines before we launch, not in response to an incident. In Phase 1, we moderate everything personally. Human moderation always before automated tools.
HIGH	Mentor Burnout <i>Risk:</i> The most helpful upper-years start getting the same questions over and over. It stops feeling rewarding. They quietly disappear, and first-years notice. <i>Fix:</i> Build a searchable archive of good answers so they don't have to repeat themselves. Surface prior answers before someone posts a duplicate question. Recognise top contributors publicly, not with points, but with actual visibility.

MEDIUM	Feature Creep <i>Risk:</i> Users ask for group chats, events, a jobs board, a marketplace. Every request sounds reasonable. Each one pulls us further from what makes PeerPath different. <i>Fix:</i> We keep a visible 'what we're not building' list alongside the roadmap. Every feature proposal has to answer: does this make the community stronger, or just bigger?
MEDIUM	Competition <i>Risk:</i> If PeerPath works at Rotman, someone better-funded tries to copy it at U of T. <i>Fix:</i> Our moat is culture, not code. A platform with 18 months of built trust and real relationships is very hard to displace, even with money. Win deeply before expanding.
MEDIUM	Safety & Privacy <i>Risk:</i> Real names, verified identities, and vulnerable conversations in one place. When something goes wrong (harassment, a mental health crisis surfacing in the feed), we're responsible. <i>Fix:</i> Safety protocols and escalation paths need to exist before launch, not after. We need relationships with U of T's student services teams from day one.

10. Wild Ideas: The Features That Could Define Us

These aren't roadmap items. They're ideas that could become the thing people remember about PeerPath, the reason they tell a friend.

The First-Week Letter

Every incoming first-year gets a personal letter (not a template) written by a randomly matched second-year in their program, sent before orientation. 'Here's what I wish I'd known.' We create belonging before the student sets foot on campus. No app feature does that.

Courses as Living Archives

Every course at U of T gets a PeerPath space automatically. Students verify by uploading their timetable. The magic: past students' questions and answers from prior years are still there, searchable. You can read what a third-year was confused about in Week 6 of RSM332 two years ago. The course stops being a black box.

The Reputation Graph

No badges. Instead, a quiet, permanent record on your profile: 'Nathan helped 47 students with recruiting questions this year. Mentioned by name in 12 posts. Three people credited him when they got their offers.' That's social capital made visible. It motivates in a way that a badge never could. Because it's real.

The Annual Handoff

Every April, graduating students write one thing: a letter to their first-year self. We curate them and send them to incoming students in September. The graduating class's hard-won wisdom becomes the orientation gift for the class behind them. It becomes a tradition, not a product feature.

11. Execution Timeline

Month	What We're Doing	How We Know It's Working
0–1	Incorporate. Buy the domain. Launch a simple waitlist page at Rotman.	Legal entity set up. 100 signups from people we've personally spoken to.
1–2	Build MVP: verified login, course feed, DM, weekly email digest.	Working product. 30 beta testers from our personal network actively using it.
2–3	Soft launch. Personal invitations only. No announcement.	50 active users. Zero unanswered questions older than 24 hours.
3–4	Secure Commerce Society endorsement. Expand invite list carefully.	200 active users. Week-over-week retention above 60%.
4–6	Study what's working. Find the top 20 contributors. Start building reputation layer.	We can name our top contributors. Qualitative interviews with 30 users done.
6–9	Expand to 2 more U of T faculties with ambassadors already in place.	500 active users across 3 faculties with distinct community cultures.
9–12	Decide: keep bootstrapping or raise. Apply to CDL or ICUBE if numbers are right.	We have a clear answer. If raising, we have a compelling data story.
12–18	First university outside U of T. First part-time hire on the team.	1,500 active users. At least one real revenue conversation underway.

12. Brand & Tone

PeerPath should feel like a smart, generous older sibling. Someone who's been exactly where you are, remembers what it felt like, and wants to help, without making you feel stupid for asking. Not corporate. Not chaotic. Warm and direct.

Warm	Honest	Curious	Generous
Grounded	Human	Encouraging	Unpretentious

We don't 'leverage community touchpoints' or 'empower student stakeholders.' We write like a thoughtful upper-year talking to a first-year in the library: honest, unhurried, and without any jargon.

"The best communities aren't built on one-way mentorship. They're built on the idea that everyone has something to teach and something to learn. It just depends on who's in the room and what the question is. That's what we're building."

PeerPath, June 2026

Confidential. Prepared by Daniyal Rashid, Nathan Ho & Jackson Del Ciano, Rotman Commerce, University of Toronto.